> into rivers, and formed paddy fields, and gathered together a store of grain. . . . Thus did this wise ruler make the revenue that was obtained from the new paddy fields alone to be greater than the revenue which had been derived from the old paddy fields in the [entire] kingdom; and when he had accomplished this he made the country so prosperous that the inhabitants should never know the evils of famine.[4]

The sequel to *The Mahavansa* credits Parakrama Bahu with building (or rebuilding) 165 dams, nearly 4,000 canals, and nearly 2,500 reservoirs.[5]

His religious reforms were equally energetic.

Parakrama's ancestor Vijaya Bahu, driving away the Hindu occupiers, had ruled his new kingdom as a Buddhist king. In the century since, Buddhist temples and monasteries had risen to replace the Shiva shrines. The most magnificent of these temples was the home of the Buddha's Tooth; the tooth, said to be one of the seven unburned relics that survived the Buddha's cremation, had been brought to the island in the fourth century and been kept safe from the Hindu regime. Parakrama himself had fought for the Buddha's Tooth, taking it away from a rival ruler in his battle to unify the island and enshrining it in his capital city.[6]

But the Buddhism of the island was still interlaced with Hindu practice, and its monks and priests were divided and quarreling. Three *nikayas,* or monastic orders, struggled for dominance in the capital. They feuded over the rules of monasticism, the interpretation of Buddhist scriptures, and control of the temples. Parakrama's kingdom had barely begun its existence as a single nation, and for the monks, who were the heart of the country's religious practice, to remain divided into three parts would only serve to drive wedges into the barely joined fractures between the old three nations.

Seeking help, Parakrama Bahu turned to Mahakassapa, the senior monk at a nearby forest monastery. Forest monasteries had a character different from that of city or village monasteries; the monks tended to be more austere, less interested in political wrangling, stricter in practice. Forest monasteries were places of quiet meditation, not loud conflict; in the forest, removed from the centers of power, the monks were thought to gain a detachment and clarity that was missing from the bustling, wealthy monasteries of the cities.[7]

In 1165, acting on Mahakassapa's advice, Parakrama Bahu summoned the leaders of all three *nikayas* to a council. There he declared that as king—his sacred right to rule proven by his victories over his enemies and by his protection of the Buddha's Tooth—he would abolish all three monastic orders. Instead, there would be only two kinds of monks: *gamavasin* and *arannavasin,* village dwellers and forest dwellers. To prevent quarreling, he